

Pursuit of Happiness
A Financial Dashboard for 2024

Venkata Sai Varun Vedula

31 May 2025, 09:30 p.m.

Introduction

Ever since I can remember, I have been the kind of person who loves keeping a close eye on where my money goes. Whether it's jotting down expenses after a grocery run or reviewing my spending at the end of each month, tracking my finances isn't just a routine—it's a habit that gives me insight, discipline, and sometimes even a reason to celebrate. If I catch myself overspending in a particular month, I course-correct. If I manage to stay within my limits or save more than planned, I make sure to pat myself on the back.

But this year, I wanted to take my financial self-awareness a step further. Instead of relying on scattered notes or static spreadsheets, I set out to answer a simple question: Can I turn my financial data into a clear, compelling story—one that helps me see not just the "what," but the "why" behind my earning and spending patterns?

That's what inspired this project. Using Tableau, I transformed my raw 2024 transaction data into a minimalistic yet powerful dashboard that not only summarizes the numbers but brings my financial journey to life. My goal wasn't just analysis—it was storytelling. I wanted each chart, annotation, and design choice to help me (and anyone else viewing the dashboard) understand the bigger picture, learn from the past, and make smarter decisions for the future.

Background and Motivation

My interest in storytelling goes way back—even before I picked up a camera or edited my first film. But it was at Kent State University, during my very first Data Visualization class, that I realized how powerfully stories can be told through data. I'll never forget my professor's opening remarks: *"Data visualization is all about storytelling."* That stuck with me. As a filmmaker, I was used to creating stories with visuals and sound; now, I was being challenged to do it with charts and numbers.

Shortly after that, life gave me the perfect setting for my own story. Arriving in the U.S. as an international student, I suddenly had to manage every dollar carefully. From tuition and rent to groceries and the occasional treat, I was always alert—making sure every transaction was

tracked. Back home, I would jot down expenses with pen and paper just to keep myself in check. But now, I wanted to do more than just record numbers—I wanted to see the bigger picture.

Inspired by my professor's advice and fuelled by my own filmmaker's curiosity, I decided to approach my finances like an analyst. What if I could turn my day-to-day transactions into a visual story? What patterns would emerge? What lessons could I learn about myself?

That's how this project began: a way to blend my love for storytelling with my need to keep a close watch on my spending—a journey from tracking expenses to discovering the story behind every dollar.

Project Objectives

- To practice and refine the art of storytelling through minimalism—finding the most effective and simple ways to communicate my financial story without relying on complex visuals or a multitude of colors.
- To turn my 2024 earnings and expenses into clear, compelling visual narratives that are easy to understand at a glance.
- To highlight patterns, outliers, and key trends that can guide smarter financial decisions.
- To maximize the use of my data by thinking like an analyst—integrating predictive and scenario-based features such as “What-if” analysis to explore how small changes in spending could make a real impact.

Tools & Technologies Used

- Tableau - for all data visualization and dashboarding.
- Excel - to perform initial data cleaning, consolidation, and simple categorization.
- Annotation (within Tableau) - to add context and storytelling to charts.

Data Description

The dataset included every transaction—income and expense—for the year 2024. Each entry featured:

- Date (month and day)
- Amount
- Type (Money In/Money Out)
- Category (e.g., Rent, Grocery, Lifestyle, etc.)
- Payee/Vendor (Ajith, Credit Card, Teja, etc.)

Data Preparation Steps:

- Removed duplicates and corrected entry errors.
- Standardized all categories and payee names for consistency.
- Ensured that each transaction was accurately labelled and categorized.

Visualization Walkthrough

1 KPI - 2024 Overview

Purpose: To present, up front, the essential summary: how much I earned and how much I spent in 2024.

KPI		
Year of Date	Money In	Money Out
2024	\$10,560	\$7,456

Details:

Money In: \$10,560

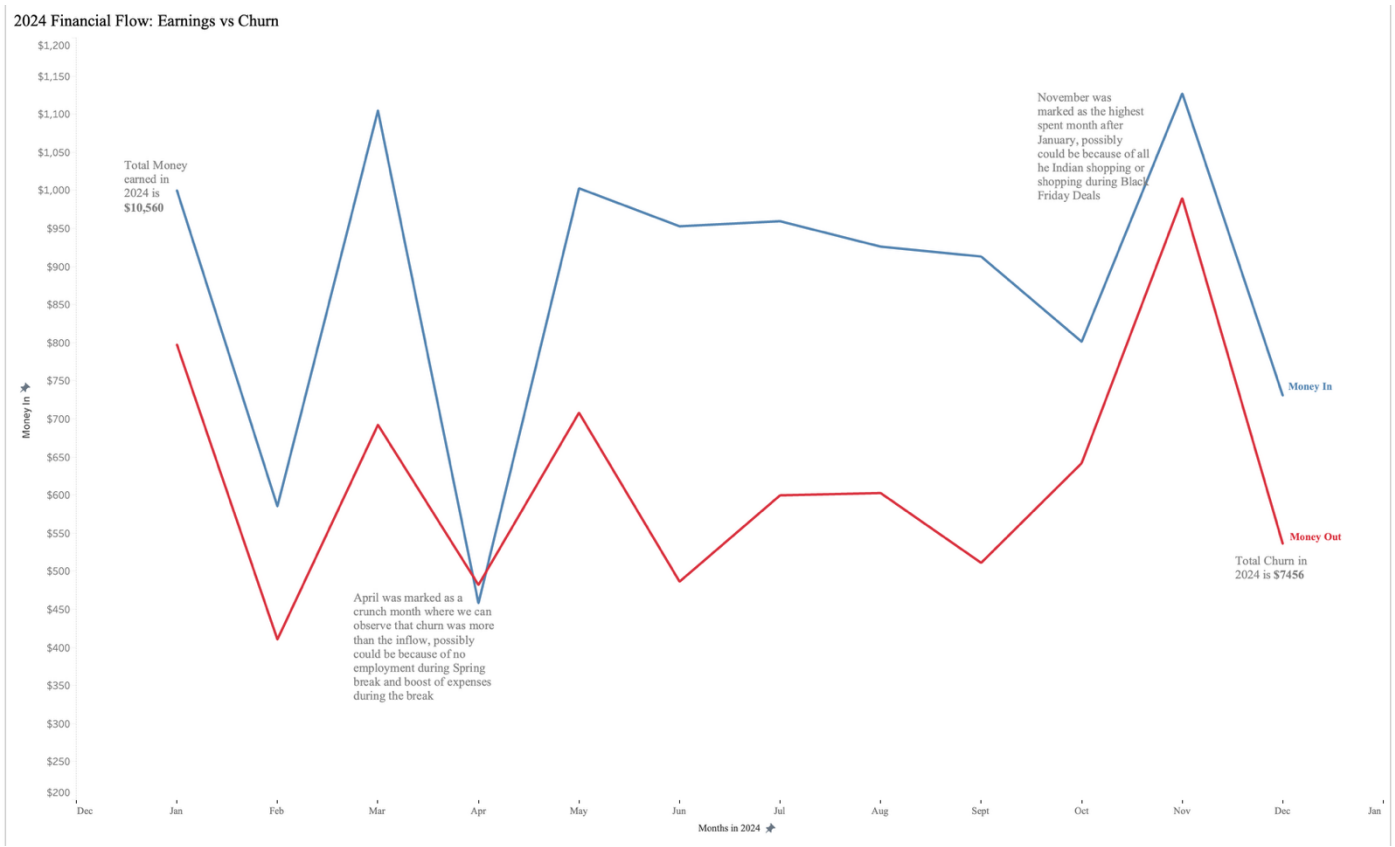
Money Out: \$7,456

Net Savings: \$3,104

Design Note: The minimalist white space and bold font help the key figures stand out, keeping attention on what matters most.

2 2024 Financial Flow: Earnings vs Churn

Purpose: To visualize monthly trends and spot fluctuations in income and expenses throughout the year.



Details:

The blue line (Money In) and red line (Money Out) show clear peaks and valleys.

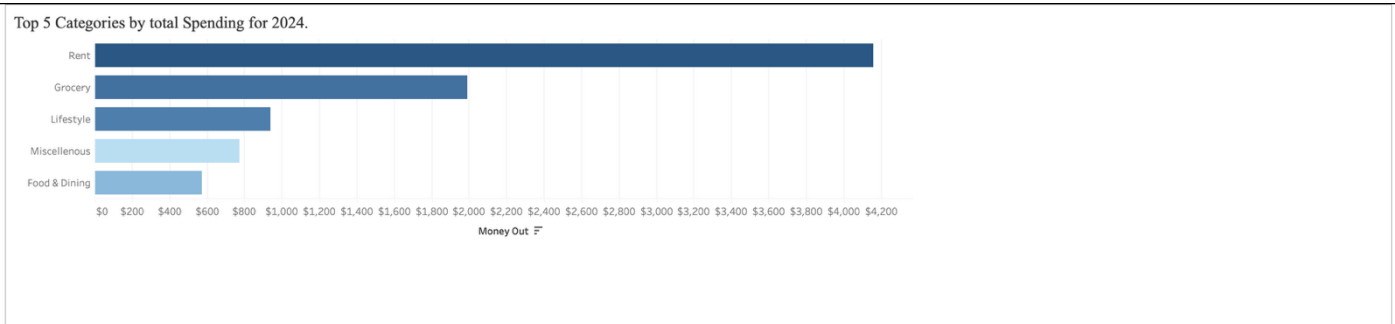
Notable insights:

- April stands out as a “crunch month” where spending surpassed income, likely due to a spring break with less work and more discretionary spending.
- November also emerges as a high-spend month, possibly due to Black Friday or festive shopping.

Design Note: I used annotations directly on the chart to call attention to these months, so the narrative is built right into the visualization.

3 Top 5 Categories by Total Spending

Purpose: To quickly identify where most of my money went in 2024.



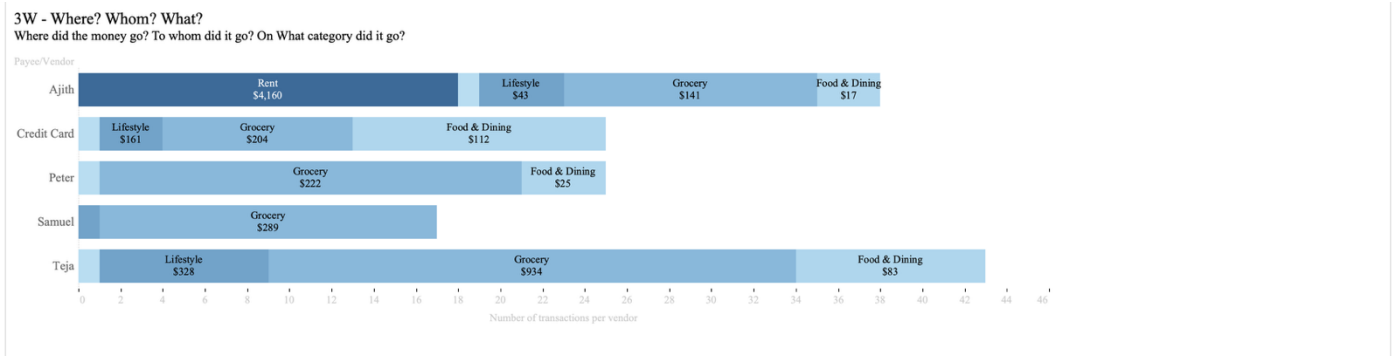
Details:

- Rent is by far the largest expense, followed by Grocery and Lifestyle.
- Miscellaneous and Food & Dining round out the top five.

Design Note: The horizontal bar chart with shades of blue allows instant comparison—no numbers are hidden, and categories are sorted by impact.

4 3W – Where?, Whom?, What?

Purpose: To break down spending by both payee and category—answering “Where did my money go, to whom, and on what?”



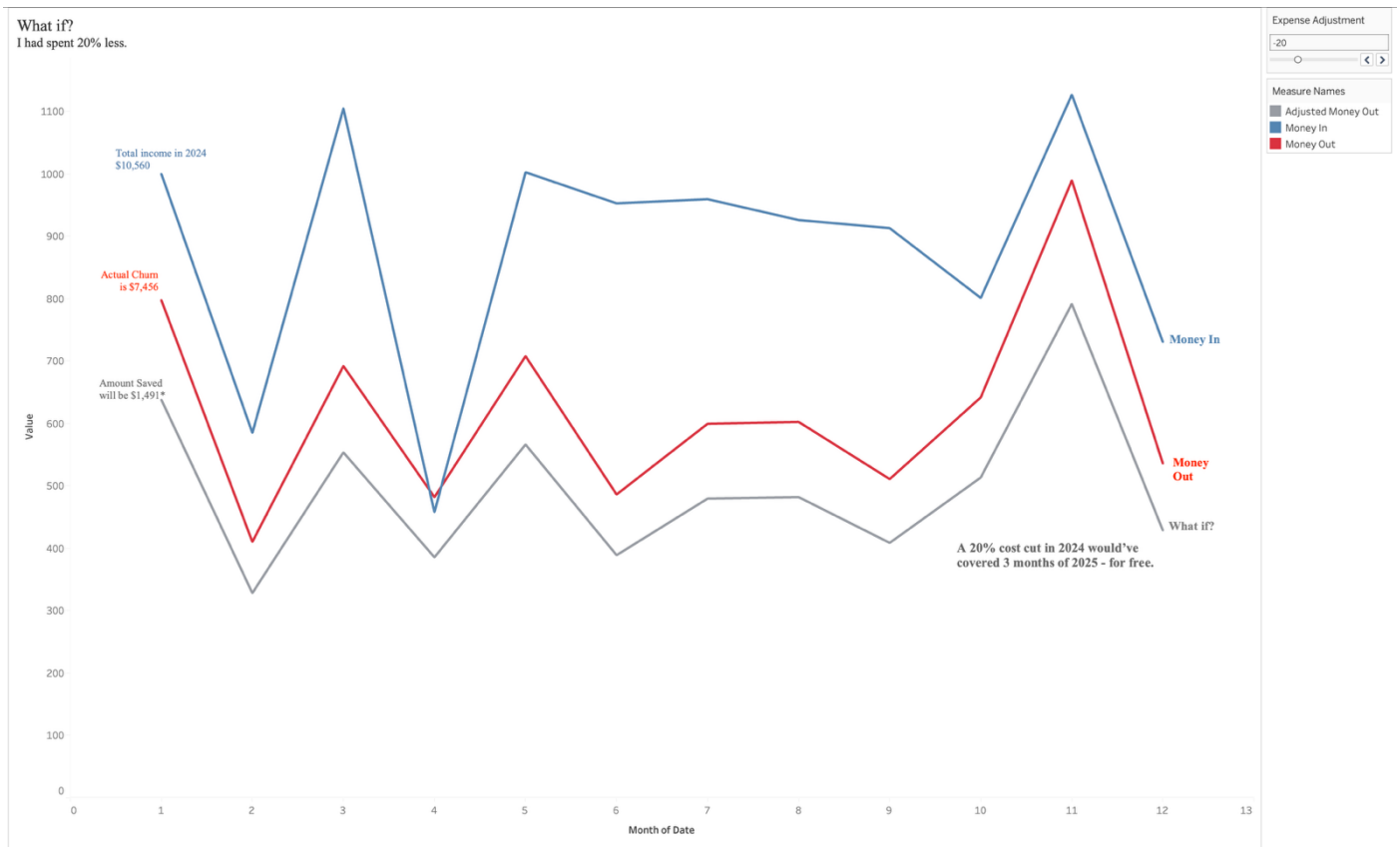
Details:

- The visual maps major payees (Ajith, Teja, Credit Card, etc.) to categories like Rent, Grocery, and Lifestyle.

Design Note: This granular view helps pinpoint not only which category is consuming more but also through which channel or person the spending is flowing.

5 What IF?

Purpose: To simulate how much I could have saved with small behavioral changes—in this case, spending 20% less each month.



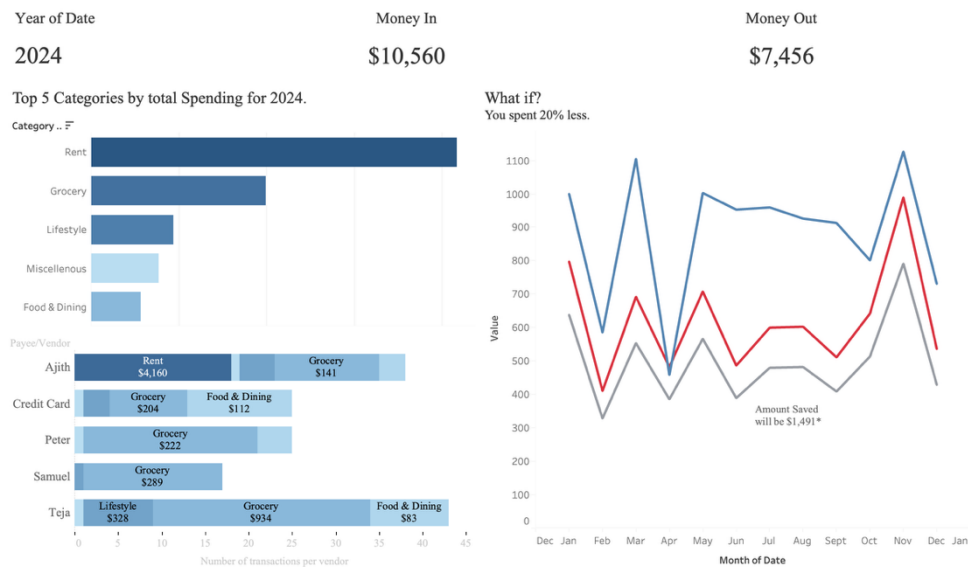
Details:

- An interactive slider (custom cursor) allows dynamic adjustment of the expense reduction percentage.
- The grey line shows "Adjusted Money Out," while blue and red lines display actual income and expenses.

Key Insight: Spending 20% less in 2024 would have saved \$1,491, enough to cover 3 months of expenses in 2025 for free.

6 Final Dashboard - 2024 Financial Analysis.

2024 Financial Analysis



Design & Impact:

- KPIs at the top provide instant context.
- The Top 5 Categories and 3W charts offer a quick breakdown of where money went.
- The What If? Scenario chart closes the loop, quantifying potential improvements and tying the story back to practical action.
- The layout, whitespace, and ordering were chosen to make the dashboard feel light, uncluttered, and immediately useful.

Storytelling Techniques Used

1. Signal-to-Noise: I made sure my dashboard highlights only the most important information. Anything that didn't add value was left out, so it's easy to focus on what matters.
2. Data-Ink Ratio: I kept the visuals clean by using just enough lines, text, and colors to show the data—no extra decorations or distractions.
3. Gestalt Principles: I grouped similar information and used the same colors for similar things. This helps make patterns and connections clear right away.

4. Strategic Contrast: I used bold colors only when I needed to draw attention to something important, like an outlier or key trend.
5. Choosing the Right Visuals: I used simple bar charts for category comparisons and line charts to show changes over time, avoiding complicated or confusing visuals.
6. What-If Analysis: I added a "What-If" tool that lets me see how things would change if I spent less, making the dashboard not just informative, but practical for planning.

Visual Design Philosophy

1. I chose a minimal colour palette—mainly blue, red, and neutral tones—to keep the visuals calm, clear, and easy on the eyes.
2. White space is used intentionally throughout the dashboard, making each view feel open rather than crowded and helping key numbers and charts stand out.
3. For text, I used Times New Roman. This classic font brings a sense of professionalism and readability to every title, label, and annotation.
4. I kept fonts, chart types, and sizes consistent across every sheet, making the overall design clean, unified, and easy to navigate.

Challenges Faced and How I Overcame Them

1. Messy Data: My records weren't always perfect. I spent time cleaning up categories and fixing typos to make sure the data was reliable.
2. Choosing What to Show: It was tempting to include every chart or number. I learned to prioritize only the visuals that truly added insight, keeping the dashboard clean and focused.
3. Balance Between Detail and Simplicity: Finding the right amount of information—enough to be useful, but not so much as to overwhelm—took several rounds of revision.
4. Building Interactivity: Setting up the "What-If" tool in Tableau was challenging at first, but it made the dashboard much more practical and valuable.

5. **Maintaining Consistency:** Ensuring the design stayed simple and consistent across every sheet and view required ongoing attention.

Key Insights and Impact

1. I can now see, at a glance, where my money goes each month and where I tend to overspend.
2. The dashboard makes it easy to identify spending patterns—whether by month, category, or recipient.
3. The “What-If” feature helps me experiment with scenarios, making it easier to set realistic goals and plan for the future.
4. Overall, this process has helped me become more intentional with my finances and more confident in my ability to manage them.

Conclusion

Transforming my financial data into a minimalist Tableau dashboard was more than just an analytics exercise—it was a chance to tell my own story, learn from it, and use those lessons to grow. By focusing on clarity, simplicity, and purpose-driven design, I’ve created a tool that helps me understand, reflect, and plan—making my finances not just easier to manage, but also more meaningful.